Building ASEAN Identity Through Regional Diplomacy

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Introduction

When the historic Bangkok Declaration was signed on 8 August 1967, creating the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN), the region was confronted with conflicts and the potential instability largely because of Cold War tensions. After 53 years of enlargement and development, ASEAN is viewed as one of the more successful regional organisations in the world. The ASEAN leaders launched the ASEAN Community in 2015 to underline ASEAN's centrality and its role as the driving force in addressing the evolving regional architecture in South East Asia. ASEAN centrality is about maintaining ASEAN's relevance and ASEAN's convening power to manage regional processes for dialogue (Chalermpalanupap, 2017). ASEAN centrality calls on ASEAN member states to prioritise ASEAN in fulfilling its regional commitments by remaining united, strengthening co-ordination and contributing as a cohesive group (Ong, 2007).

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The launch of the ASEAN Community was also a move towards ASEAN being forward-looking and people-centred, departing from the former ASEAN way of doing things, which was slow, status quo and state-centric (Hernandez, n.d). It was a progressive development in response to integration and community building needs as well as the growing levels of comfort, trust and political maturity among ASEAN member states over the years (Hoang, 2017). The development and the adoption of the ASEAN Charter at the 13th ASEAN Summit in November 2007 and its ratification paved the way for consultations with non-state actors and the use of Track II dialogues to include their peoples in community building (Hernandez, n.d).

The community building approach now takes a people-centred approach to strive for further integration and stronger cohesiveness among member states. As a regional organisation composed of small- to medium-sized states, ASEAN cultivates a strong voice in the world through its institutional regional identity. On the other hand, there is a perception that ASEAN co-operation is more about high politics and diplomacy than about the day-to-day issues that affect the 650 million people in South East Asia. Diplomacy appears to have little impact on ordinary people's lives (Thuzar, 2014). But ASEAN's efforts in diplomacy allow the region to reap the benefits of stability, economic success and improved living standards. Yet ordinary people often do not know about ASEAN's accomplishments that allow them to go about their business in tranquillity (Thuzar, 2015).

This chapter highlights ASEAN's relative success at the level of state decision-making in forging its institutional identity building through regional diplomacy efforts, and because of this progress, the priority task ahead is to get the ordinary people of ASEAN to rally behind the ASEAN community building process. Popular support is necessary for the further development of ASEAN over the next fifty years. Strengthening ASEAN identity allows its wider public to be more involved in its regional co-operation efforts in order that issues that affect daily life in South East Asia matter. It also discusses the role of the ASEAN Foundation in recent years to promote ASEAN awareness and identity by targeting youth in the region to connect and collaborate with one another.

Dividends of Peace

ASEAN was established to keep peace. Its community building process is anchored on peace and freedom, economic prosperity and better quality of life for its people. The ASEAN Community captures ASEAN's resilience and dynamism. It is a community of opportunities for all, consisting of three pillars—political security, economic and sociocultural—and its launch at the end of December 2015 was viewed as a historic milestone. It was an announcement of how far ASEAN had come and how well the ASEAN member states have achieved working together (ASEAN, 2015). It is a journey spanning more than five decades where the representatives of ASEAN member states came together in friendship and co-operation to pursue the dream of ASEAN's founding fathers to improve the lives of its peoples.

ASEAN has made tremendous strides in promoting peace and stability in the region. It adopted an outward-oriented development strategy. This has resulted in ASEAN's economies remaining robust despite uncertainties in the regional and global economies. The region's free trade agreement among ASEAN member states, the ASEAN Free Trade Area agreement (AFTA) was signed in 1992. AFTA eliminated tariffs to reduce the price of products manufactured within ASEAN. It gave rise to the goal of creating a single market and production base to attract foreign direct investment and expand intra-ASEAN trade and investment, and now AFTA is in place it is challenged by domestic acceptance and enforcement of regional commitments. ASEAN's external economic relations have met with greater success, as can been seen by several free trade agreements (FTAs) with countries throughout the world, including those with China and India (Thuzar, 2014).

According to a McKinsey Global Institute report, ASEAN comprises eight of the 18 developing economies that averaged at least 3.5% annual per capita GDP growth over 50 years, or 5% annual growth over 20 years (Das et al., 2018). ASEAN has doubled its share in the world's GDP from 3.3% in 1967 to 6.5% in 2018. Real GDP growth for 2018 stood at 52%, with forecasted growth of 4.9% for 2019, according to the Asian Development Bank (ASEAN, 2019a).

Preliminary ASEAN statistics also indicate that total merchandise trade in 2018 grew by an estimated 8.1% year-on-year to reach US$2.8 trillion, while foreign direct investment (FDI) inflows increased by 5.3% year-on-year to reach US$154.7 billion (ASEAN, 2019a) With a combined

GDP of US$3 trillion in 2018, ASEAN in that year was collectively the fifth-largest economy in the world, and the third-largest economy in Asia. ASEAN's combined population of 650 million people is the third largest in the world, representing 8.7% of the world's population in 2018. It has a growing middle class that offers opportunities for investment in the region. ASEAN has emerged as a preferred destination for investment, attracting US$154.7 billion of foreign direct investment net flows in 2018, which was a significant increase from US$21.8 billion in 2000 (ASEAN, n.d).

ASEAN has a young population. The youth of ASEAN, defined here as persons aged fifteen to 35, represent over 33% of ASEAN's population and are key stakeholders in its contribution to ASEAN's future. The 213 million youth who constitute the region's largest-ever cohort is expected to rise to a peak of 220 million in 2038. Except for Singapore and Thailand, the youth population in the rest of the ASEAN member states is between 25 and 30% of their respective total populations. This augurs well for the region as it is attractive as a market because of its growing consumer base (ASEAN, 2017a).

Another McKinsey report states that some 67 million households in ASEAN states are part of the 'consuming class', with incomes exceeding the level at which they can begin to make significant discretionary purchases. That number could almost double to 125 million households by 2025, making ASEAN a pivotal consumer market of the future. At the same time ASEAN cities are booming because of urbanisation. Today, 22% of ASEAN's population lives in cities of more than 200,000 inhabitants and these urban centres account for more than 54% of the region's GDP. An additional 54 million people are expected to move to cities by 2025. ASEAN consumers are increasingly moving online, with mobile penetration of 110% and internet penetration of 25% across the region. ASEAN member states make up the world's second-largest community of Facebook users, behind only the United States, but the adoption of social media varies in the different countries (HV et al., 2014).

With the formation of ASEAN, member states concentrated their efforts to improve the quality of life of ASEAN's peoples. Progress is reflected by the reduced proportion of people living on less than US$1.25 per day, from one in two to one in eight persons over the last two decades. (ASEAN, 2015). There was a reduction in maternal mortality per 100,000 live births from 286 in 1990 to 197 in 2015. The proportion of the population with improved sanitation facilities increased from

37% in 1990 to 78% in 2015. Examples of stability brought about by regional co-operation include an increase in the net enrolment ratio in primary education from 83% in 1990 to 96% in 2015 and an increase in the proportion of seats held by women in parliaments from 9% in 1995 to 18% in 2015 (ASEAN, 2017b).

Increasing a Sense of Belonging

When ASEAN celebrated its 50th anniversary in 2017, there was much praise for the institution, as highlighted by the World Economic Forum's regional focus on ASEAN in Phnom Penh in 2017 to Economic Research Institute for ASEAN and East Asia (ERIA)'s ASEAN@50 volume, *The ASEAN Journey: Reflections of ASEAN Leaders and Officials*, as well as Kishore Mahbubani and Jeffery Sng's *The ASEAN Miracle: A Catalyst for Peace*. It has helped keep the peace for the last fifty years in a diverse region comprising ethnically and culturally diverse people, and different religious and political systems. Its diplomatic platform regularly brought together major powers such as the United States, the European Union, China, India, Japan, Russia, and South and North Korea creating a conducive environment for them to talk to each other. ASEAN's rich experience of managing such stakeholders' interests and the 'ASEAN Plus' processes such as ASEAN Plus Three (the ten ASEAN countries, China, Japan and the Republic of Korea) and the East Asia Summit (ASEAN, China, Japan, the Republic of Korea, India, Australia and New Zealand) have mutually engaged these stakeholders in an orderly and rewarding manner. As a result, ASEAN has been recognised as playing a central role and has been acknowledged to be the 'the primary driver' of regional architecture development in East Asia. In the process, a nascent regional identity was being built among government officials because of a common purpose of promoting solidarity and co-operation on the regional stage (Ong, 2009).

ASEAN currently holds more than 1,000 meetings every year. The constant interaction and co-operation among government officials at these meetings can result in an 'invisible formal network' being developed that can lead to top-level community building (Mahbubani & Severino, 2014). Developing shared norms like dialogue, consultation and consensus, known as the 'ASEAN Way', into customised mechanisms has helped promote a strong sense of common identity. ASEAN's framework and community building have enriched the organisation's standing,

notwithstanding the imperfections of the regional body. This in turn has enhanced the political and strategic position of each member state. This has elevated ASEAN's prestige and recognition, increasing a sense of belonging to a region (Ong, 2009).

When the ASEAN leaders adopted the ASEAN Concord II in October 2003 with the aim of establishing the ASEAN Community by 2020, it was upon the realisation that the closeness of geography and the 'ASEAN Way' were insufficient to forge closer regional integration. It was necessary to move from the loose 'association of regional countries' into a much closer 'ASEAN community of nations'. To build a strong ASEAN Community, a genuine sense of belonging to the region and shared destiny would be critical components to instil a sense of an ASEAN identity (Lee, 2018).

There was no mention of an ASEAN identity in the Bangkok Declaration and it was not until 30 years after its adoption that the 'promotion of ASEAN awareness' appeared in the 1997 Hanoi Plan of Action. Furthermore, the word 'identity' entered the ASEAN lexicon through the Bali Concord II in 2003, which laid the foundation for the ASEAN Community's formation by 2020, which was pushed forward to 2015 by the ASEAN Leaders in 2007 (Murti, 2016). Global events, starting with free trade areas being established in Europe and North America, the Asian financial crisis and the rise of China pushed ASEAN to adopt the Bali Concord II, seeking to establish an ASEAN Community by 2020. ASEAN had to remain relevant. ASEAN leaders recognised that integration and community building require some degree of similarities in the economic, political and sociocultural development of member states. There would be a need to include the interests and expectations of the peoples of ASEAN in its goals as well as in the shaping of its decisions (Hernandez, n.d.).

Paragraph 10 of the Bali Concord II stated that ASEAN shall continue to foster a community of caring societies and promote a common regional identity. It was a momentous step towards regional integration. Ever since Bali Concord II, it has been recognised that establishing a community requires a sense of common identity, which ASEAN has actively promoted ever since (Murti, 2016). ASEAN's motto of 'One Vision, One Identity, One Community' was adopted at the 11th ASEAN Summit in December 2005. The motto acknowledges that for the ASEAN Community to be real, fostering a sentiment of 'we-feeling' must be inculcated among the peoples of this region. This 'we-feeling' will inform regional efforts

and facilitate better co-operation in the political, security, economic and sociocultural arenas (Lee, 2018).

ASEAN Identity as an Institutional Identity

Currently, the ASEAN identity is largely institutional. It finds expression in all the ASEAN meetings, summits, agreements and blueprints, and is also reflected by all the ASEAN institutions, programmes, initiatives and processes. The most prominent ASEAN institutions and processes are the ASEAN summits and the ASEAN Secretariat. They also include the numerous ASEAN committees and working groups, as well as the hundreds of meetings held every year. Over time, an ASEAN institutional identity has evolved and consolidated. As ASEAN grew, the organisation expanded its range of initiatives to include blueprints and action plans under the ASEAN Economic Community (AEC), the ASEAN Socio-Cultural Community (ASCC) and the ASEAN Political-Security Community (APSC). Hence, ASEAN's institutional identity, which was originally constructed to settle disputes and ensure peace in the region, enlarged in terms of organisational processes but was not as centralised or as bureaucratic as the European Union, which ASEAN is often compared to (ERIA, 2015).

The institutional identity of ASEAN that has become its top brand, the ASEAN Way, is synonymous with how ASEAN engages with both its members and its external partners (Chongkittavorn, 2019). It encompasses the shared principles guiding ASEAN, namely the culture of non-interference and non-intervention to resolve conflicts among the members of ASEAN. The ASEAN Way involves mutual consensus and more informal understandings and loose agreements instead of a more formal and legalistic manner of working, to increase co-operation among its members (Woon, 2016). This way of working has kept ASEAN together despite the diversity in the region from the perspective of socio-cultural, economic and political differences, along with mistrust between different members (Ebbighausen, 2017).

At the same time, the institutional identity of ASEAN includes having an ASEAN emblem, the ASEAN flag, the ASEAN anthem and an annual ASEAN Day. These existential identities were adopted to broaden the appeal of an ASEAN identity for everyday people, instead of the ASEAN identity being institutional and confined to the bureaucratic circles (Chongkittavorn, 2019). The institutional identity of ASEAN,

which provides recognition for all, does not engender the 'we-feeling' among the peoples in the region. The perception is that ASEAN is an elitist organisation, where political leaders meet regularly, but their coming together does not affect the bulk of the 650 million people in the region. For ASEAN to matter to these people, they must feel a sense of participation in the various regional processes (Thuzar, 2014).

ASEAN Identity as a Communal Identity

The idea of ASEAN identity as a communal identity stems from the conviction of political leaders that the general population of the region must feel a shared sense of ASEAN belonging in order to support the further development of the organisation. That is, the concept of ASEAN identity has to move from a high-level institutional perspective towards a bottom-up sense of ASEAN commonality, interconnectedness, belonging, shared destiny and greater public engagement, together with a sense of wider ownership of ASEAN initiatives (ERIA, 2015).

Constructing a broader identity and community requires greater public participation and buy-in. It is about extending social relationships (Murti, 2016). The building of an ASEAN communal identity involves the deliberate promotion of initiatives, processes and sentiments of the 'we-feeling', the 'ours feeling' and the feeling that 'we are in this together'. Engendering a deep sense of a shared ASEAN identity and destiny require a more nuanced understanding of ASEAN's past to appreciate ASEAN's future. There is a need to deepen awareness of the interconnectedness among peoples within the region, facilitate people's participation and advance a sense of public ownership of the ASEAN Community (ERIA, 2015).

The quest for an ASEAN identity suffers from a gulf between the official ASEAN vision and a communal ASEAN perspective. The latter requires a conscious effort of engagement in a variety of areas, such as arts, education or tourism, that promote mutual understanding among peoples and create the 'we-feeling'. Developing a community ASEAN identity needs to be a bottom-up initiative rather than a top-down effort, and involves identity formation among peoples, not just states. ASEAN as a regional organisation will have to shed its elite-driven agenda and identity if more people are going to be involved in regional construction. This presents an especially important challenge for ASEAN (Acharya, 2017).

For a long time, ASEAN has been viewed as an elitist organisation largely controlled by diplomats and government officials that are responsible for much of the high-level interactions through governmental and bureaucratic channels. After all, ASEAN is, by definition, an intergovernmental organisation. Over the past decade, the ASEAN organisation has been trying to connect to the grassroots through consultation and engagement with many stakeholders, especially business and civil society, to get their views and feedback regarding making regional policy. However, many such consultations still focus more on form than substance, especially at the summit level (Hoang, 2017). The outreach to the wider public remains limited.

The creation of a communal ASEAN identity is getting ordinary people involved so that they feel they have a direct stake in the association. This is crucial to deepening and speeding up regional integration efforts. Nevertheless, a sense of ASEAN detachment from the general population was highlighted by the Malaysian Prime Minister Najib Razak during the 27th ASEAN Summit in Kuala Lumpur in November 2015. He was quoted as saying that 'many still cannot relate to ASEAN and its significance, they are still unable to appreciate ASEAN' (Lim, 2015). Similarly, Singapore's Prime Minister Lee Hsien Loong, during an interview at the summit, stressed the need for forging a shared ASEAN identity because

> one of the reasons ASEAN finds it difficult to make progress together is [that] there is not a very strong sense of ASEAN identity: it's really a Singaporean identity, a Malaysian identity or Indonesian identity. People don't think of themselves as being ASEAN, except when you have an ASEAN meeting and you have singsongs together and you see what the ideal is. But to go from that ideal to a reality, I think there is some distance yet. (Lim, 2015)

At the 27th ASEAN Summit, the leaders adopted the 'ASEAN 2025: Forging Ahead Together' document as the reference for the next stage of ASEAN community building efforts. The focus of the ASEAN community building in the next ten years will be, among others:

- Placing greater emphasis on the peoples of ASEAN and their well-being.
- Enhancing awareness of ASEAN and its vision of a politically cohesive, economically integrated and socially responsible community.

- Engaging all nationals of ASEAN member states through effective and innovative platforms to promote commitment and identification with ASEAN policies and regional interests.
- Ensuring fundamental freedoms, human rights and better lives for all ASEAN peoples.

The above goals are in principle shared and understood by ASEAN at the institutional and government level, but are limited at the grassroots level. It remains to be seen whether the peoples of ASEAN know about them, really understand, and share what is being envisioned and captured in the ASEAN 2025 document. Expanding an ASEAN identity into a wider, communal identity is largely a matter of feeling, awareness and connection. ASEAN's history has largely been associated with government activities, which have changed the nature of relations between the ASEAN member states. In moving forward, ASEAN member states should use ASEAN instruments and frameworks by integrating and streamlining them into domestic policies, programmes, practices and modalities (Natalegawa, 2018). Doing so allows for a broad-based ASEAN identity to flourish, as citizens in the region can appreciate and understand ASEAN and how its developments affect their day-to-day lives.

An expanded ASEAN identity could facilitate recognition of the shared historical heritage and cultural traits which existed long before the establishment of ASEAN. It is about celebrating shared stories of the vast interconnected histories of the region instead of narrating the experiences of decolonisation of the many countries in the region. Hence, raising a broader understanding and awareness of ASEAN through greater information sharing and enhancing mutual understanding through people-to-people interaction can allow people to contribute to building ASEAN as a community (Tan, 2020).

ASEAN Awareness

Surveys on ASEAN awareness and identity have been conducted since 2007. They show that public awareness of ASEAN in member states appears to be getting stronger (Murti, 2016). Measuring to what extent ordinary people know about ASEAN and what it does to impact on the lives of ordinary people can be challenging. The latest survey is the Poll on ASEAN Awareness commissioned by the ASEAN Secretariat in 2018.

It revealed that 96% of over 4,400 respondents in the ten member states were aware of ASEAN, and 66% of the respondents believed that a shared identity is essential in creating a stronger region. Yet less than one-third claimed to have knowledge of the ASEAN Community and its three pillars. At the same time, 90% of the respondents identified themselves firstly by nationality (98%), then as an Asian (96%) and as an ASEAN citizen (94%) (Tan, 2020).

In 2016, ERIA developed a public opinion survey to ask over 2,000 respondents comprise students, labour, business, government officials, civil society, academia and others, a series of questions regarding the concerns, aspirations and expectations of ASEAN people for ASEAN. The result showed that all respondents were at least 'slightly familiar' with ASEAN, while three-fifths of them were 'moderately' to 'very' familiar with ASEAN. Like the 2018 survey, respondents in the 2016 examination of public opinion were mostly aware of ASEAN's economic pillar.

Interestingly in ERIA's survey, older respondents (those aged 50 or over) generally tended to be more familiar with ASEAN than younger respondents (those aged 15–30). Also, those respondents who were academics and government officials tended to be more aware of ASEAN than the other groups, especially students. In the focus group discussions (FGDs), a number of participants said they had learned about ASEAN first in their primary school, high school or university classes, while there were also a number who had learned about ASEAN only in 2015 from the news and media as the ASEAN member states prepared for the realisation of the AEC.

Besides these two recent surveys, two other known studies on ASEAN awareness targeted undergraduate students. These were conducted by the ISEAS-Yusof Ishak Institute in 2007 and 2014. The first survey, on 'Awareness and Attitudes towards ASEAN', was undertaken in ten universities in the main cities of ASEAN countries, from September to November 2007. The 2014 version aimed to update the findings of the 2007 survey. There was a strong trend in the commonality of responses and overall positive attitudes towards ASEAN throughout the region in both the 2007 and 2014 surveys. Positive attitudes towards ASEAN have remained generally consistent, while awareness and knowledge of ASEAN have shown some increase. Overall, the student survey participants displayed good knowledge of ASEAN, held positive attitudes towards ASEAN and considered themselves 'citizens of ASEAN' (over 80%) (ISEAS and ASEAN Foundation, n.d.).

Subsequent surveys following the two evaluations by the ISEAS-Yusof Ishak Institute indicated a growing awareness of ASEAN—perhaps because of all the news about the establishment of the AEC in 2015. In the ISEAS's 2014 survey of students, only 56% were aware of ASEAN—this jumped to 87% in ERIA's survey in 2016. However, comments during the FGDs made it clear that much of the participants' awareness was related to ASEAN's economic pillar. Indeed, several respondents stated that they believed the AEC and ASEAN were the same. Many respondents could not identify the other two pillars of ASEAN. Considering some of the key findings related to the challenges and aspirations for ASEAN (which are largely non-economic in nature), awareness limited only to ASEAN's economic pillar is an issue that should be addressed (ERIA, 2017a). The 2018 Poll on ASEAN Awareness survey by the ASEAN Secretariat supported this finding, where respondents often conflated the AEC with the ASEAN Community.

The ASEAN Foundation

ASEAN leaders have recognised that awareness of and contact among the populations of the ASEAN states was limited and, on the institution's 30th anniversary, established the ASEAN Foundation on 15 December 1997. The ASEAN Foundation was formed to try and deepen bonds for a cohesive ASEAN Community and strengthen the sense of an ASEAN identity. Now, 53 years on, ASEAN needs to intensify engagement with its peoples for them to feel the sense of a community through initiatives that revolve around their daily experiences. Since its inception in 1997, the ASEAN Foundation has managed initiatives in the ten ASEAN countries to realise its mandate. The range of projects and activities of the foundation includes training, workshops, scholarship grants, regional forums and meetings, interaction activities and exchanges, seminars and conferences, publicity and promotions. By involving various stakeholders in its efforts, the Foundation creates opportunities for ASEAN people from all walks of life to connect and bond over meaningful, shared experiences.

The ASEAN Foundation's programmes, such as ASEAN Data Science Explorers, the ASEAN Digital Innovation Programme, eMpowering Youths Across ASEAN, and ASEAN Foundation Model ASEAN Meeting, have targeted young people since they comprise 30% of ASEAN's population. The younger generation are the future of ASEAN and

the ASEAN Foundation's efforts to strengthen and foster an ASEAN identity. The programmes of the ASEAN Foundation encompass leadership training, capacity-building workshops and interactive forums at the regional level. All these activities cover topics that concern younger people and contribute to addressing ASEAN priorities. These ASEAN Foundation programmes indicate the central objective is 'to promote a people-oriented ASEAN in which all sectors of society are encouraged to participate in, and benefit from, the process of ASEAN integration and community building' (Hoang & Ong, 2020, p. 4). It is hoped that such programmes will nurture future leaders who are familiar with ASEAN issues and who can identify themselves as citizens of ASEAN.

These programmes bring together young people so that they can forge stronger ties and closer relations among themselves. It expands and strengthens the connectivity among the youth of ASEAN, hence contributing to the 'we-feeling'. In a study initiated by C asean, the research team observed that most young people believe the most important factor for successful integration among ASEAN member states is networking. Hence, having the opportunity to meet peers from different countries is invaluable. Networking allows for the development of personal skills and interaction with people from different parts of the ASEAN region. Young people that network with their peers in the region gain cultural awareness as well as technological sophistication. Leveraging on business and technology, as well as art and culture, can influence youth's mindsets and attitudes towards ASEAN. Young people are positive about new business opportunities, curious about cultural differences, comfortable with technology, are open to the world outside their communities, and most importantly, look forward to deepening ASEAN integration (Leopairote et al., 2017).

The ASEAN Foundation, in general, has succeeded in promoting awareness of ASEAN through its different programme activities largely pitched at young people. This is reflected by the high amount of interest in participation in the organisation's activities. Data obtained from an independent evaluation of the ASEAN Foundation's programme in 2019 showed high and rising interest from participants, mostly millennials, towards its programme activities. As these programme activities select participation through a competitive process, interest in applying is high among youth in the region. This is reflected in the increasing number of young applicants over the years for some programme activities of the Foundation. This, to a certain extent, reflects the broader trend in society,

especially regarding ASEAN awareness, which has also increased in recent years (Circle Indonesia, 2020).

An independent assessment of the ASEAN Foundation's programme activities in 2019 revealed that they allowed participants to acquire a better and broader awareness of ASEAN through understanding its history and the working relationship among the member states, linked with current socio-economic developments in ASEAN like poverty eradication, environment, migration and so on.

The 'we-feeling' is intensified through exhaustive interactions with participants recruited from the ten ASEAN member states over a course of a few days. The constant interaction, both formally through structured discussions and informally during breaks when mixing together with new friends, reinforced the communal ASEAN identity. In getting to know each other and forming new friends from other ASEAN member states and experiencing the different cultures from the interaction processes, participants can learn first-hand about the culture and customs of each respective member country. In this way, the participants learn about the ASEAN Community in a practical and direct way because of their interactions with their new friends (Circle Indonesia, 2020).

Besides the engagement between participants, some of the programme activities of the Foundation allow participants to engage with different stakeholders such as civil society partners, local institutions and local government bodies. Through interaction with them, the participants are introduced to different perspectives on the management of local governance in some ASEAN member states. That experience has gradually strengthened their awareness of the complexities of issues of governance and systems of government in a number of countries in South East Asia. Such activities have allowed participants to know more about what is happening on the ground, and to understand the diversity of people's lives in the ASEAN countries (Circle Indonesia, 2020). Consequently, the ASEAN Foundation has managed to play an active role in promoting public awareness of ASEAN through investment in learning, deepening connections and linkages, by building people-to-people ties among young people in the region.

The Feeling of ASEAN Citizenship

Developing a sense of ASEAN citizenship requires constant interaction that can lead to social trust (Gnanasagaran, 2018). The constant interface between diplomats and government officials allowed for an 'invisible formal network' to develop in the early days of ASEAN. With the evolution of the ASEAN Community, it becomes more critical to strengthen peoples' participation and their sense of involvement in ASEAN's activities. Interpersonal trust is strong in Asia where people and relationships matter. In the first 30 years of ASEAN's existence, there were solid connections and a strong collective memory of ASEAN among leaders from its member states. As ASEAN moves towards the future, a broader and stronger collective memory must be cultivated among the wider public (Chongkittavorn, 2015). ASEAN citizens must therefore be orientated to adopt the ASEAN Community as one of their primary identity anchors. Establishing an ASEAN Community is inadequate if the people of ASEAN do not feel a sense of identification with this community. They must feel part of it and accrue the benefits of the community building (Hoang & Ong, 2020).

The latest Poll on ASEAN Awareness revealed that across the region, 94% of the public identified themselves as ASEAN citizens at some level. This was an increase of 13 percentage points from the result of a previous study conducted by ERIA in 2017. According to the new research, two-fifths of citizens strongly affiliated themselves with ASEAN. In addition, the sense of belonging is also tied with a feeling of 'shared identity', with the economy being identified as the key factor creating a sense of belonging (ASEAN, 2019b).

The finding is underscored by an online poll that was conducted by Blackbox in Singapore in October 2017 in which 3,040 adult ASEAN citizens were surveyed across the ten ASEAN nations. The study revealed that nearly three in five (58%) of respondents believe that people born and raised in South East Asia have a lot in common, while 31% think they have at least a little in common. Furthermore, in the 2017 ERIA's ASEAN-wide survey where over 2,322 people were asked a series of questions regarding the concerns, aspirations and expectations of ASEAN people for ASEAN. More than three-quarters of all respondents felt from 'moderately' like to 'very much' like ASEAN citizens. Combined with those who indicated feeling somewhat like ASEAN citizens, a sense of ASEAN belonging was shared by virtually all the respondents. Much of this sense

of ASEAN identity is shaped by geography. A full sense of ASEAN citizenship may call for ASEAN to be more deeply engaged and more aligned with the concerns and interests of the non-elites. Only 3% of the respondents said they did not feel like they were ASEAN citizens. However, in the Blackbox poll, less than half of the respondents (43%) said they define themselves as South East Asian first ahead of being Asian (51%). Despite the lower self-identification with being South East Asian, nearly three quarters (74%) rate the current state of relationships between ASEAN member states to be positive (Chongkittavorn et al., 2019).

Meanwhile, in a 2014 survey measuring attitudes towards ASEAN among the region's university students, over 80% considered themselves as 'citizens of ASEAN'. Furthermore, most of the respondents perceived ASEAN members as similar culturally but economically and politically different (Thuzar, 2014). The most effective way to inculcate the communal identity is to create opportunities for youth to interact. Greater interaction among the different nationalities of youth in the region certainly builds strong connections and through the sharing of knowledge can spark a robust exchange of ideas that can lead to greater collaboration to grow their countries and ASEAN as a region (Chongkittavorn, 2019).

These survey results can be viewed as the fruition of the ASEAN leaders' community-building aspirations, which started with the association's establishment in 1967 when, as former ASEAN Secretary-General Rodolfo Severino explained, 'Southeast Asia's peoples hardly knew one another, having been cut off and kept isolated from one another by the colonial powers' (Intal et al., 2017, p. 4). The sense of ASEAN belonging, shaped primarily by geographic and ethnic closeness, and facilitated by the ease of travel within the region, could blossom into a full sense of ASEAN citizenship. This can be achieved as ASEAN becomes less elitist, better connected with the average person, and more aligned with the concerns and interests of the ASEAN peoples (Intal et al., 2017).

The Poll on ASEAN Awareness in 2018 surveyed the general public's perspectives on their concerns regarding the ASEAN Community. Interestingly, the top five key regional issues that the general public were concerned about were the following: protection of human rights; combating transnational crime, terrorism and drug trafficking; promotion of peace and stability in the region; prevention of corruption, and promotion of good governance and poverty reduction. The results mirrored the ERIA survey where corruption, income disparity and social inequality

are currently considered pressing challenges facing ASEAN. The pressing concerns are non-economic in nature. The implication is that people in ASEAN do not view ASEAN solely from an economic integration perspective, even though the public often equate the ASEAN Community with the economic pillar of ASEAN. This suggests that a key means of deepening the sense of ASEAN belonging, identity and citizenship—and, thus, a deep sense of the ASEAN community—is to address the common concerns of ASEAN people (Intal et al., 2017).

Conclusion

ASEAN has successfully cultivated a culture of dialogue and consultations among its member states, allowing them to exchange ideas and address differences. That is ASEAN's biggest achievement. By focusing on confidence-building and surmounting distrust and suspicion, the establishment of ASEAN has resulted in a region that has been largely peaceful for the last 53 years. ASEAN's diplomatic and economic standing have flourished, and ASEAN has often been referred to 'as the most successful regional organization after the European Union' (Mahbubani & Severino, 2014).

ASEAN's success in transforming the relationship among the countries in the region, along with the launch of the ASEAN Community, has led to increased calls for more bottom-up inputs from civil society and grassroots organisations to contribute and co-operate in the community building process. ASEAN citizens are becoming more demanding. Compared to the past, ASEAN leaders are now challenged to show the benefits of ASEAN integration. For ASEAN to thrive, the people have to be satisfied (Chongkittavorn, 2017). For ASEAN to gain wider traction among its people and for regional integration to be successful, it must not only deliver the material benefits but also create ownership and belonging. The ISEAS-Yusof Ishak Institute's ASEAN Studies Centre's State of Southeast Asia 2020 Survey Report revealed that ASEAN member states must do more to deliver tangible results to the citizens of ASEAN and be more proactive in dealing with regional challenges like the situation in Myanmar's Rakhine state. A large majority (79.4%) who were surveyed chose 'ASEAN's tangible benefits are not felt by the people' as their top concern about the regional grouping. Making ASEAN relevant to its people calls for internalising domestic support for regional commitments. ASEAN member states need to push for national implementation and

compliance with regional commitments. This is challenging as there are structural constraints, as ASEAN agreements are ratified through national implementation for the benefit of each state's people. Delays in national implementation are the biggest blockage in delivering ASEAN's benefits (Hoang & Ong, 2020).

Increasing the presence of ASEAN in the lives of its citizens across the region would mean addressing regional goals for human development and security, environmental sustainability and a shared sense of community that resonates with national priorities and local needs as well (Thuzar, 2016). Encouraging a strong sense of collaboration, and deepening strong social ties and mutual support reinforces the sustainability of sociocultural integration through the promotion of an ASEAN identity. Sociocultural integration may lead to more problematic discourse regarding how ASEAN functions or the ASEAN Way (Yu, 2020). This is a delicate balance. Nevertheless, the State of Southeast Asia 2020 Survey Report highlights the preference for a more impactful and visible ASEAN for the people of ASEAN to put their support behind the ASEAN Community. Without buy-in and ownership, ASEAN could lose support for its substantive initiatives. This could lead to a decline in ASEAN's perceived influence in the region because of its inability to communicate its work to the public (Hoang & Ong, 2020).

Improved communication and co-ordination can bridge the challenges of implementation and delivery co-ordination in ASEAN. To inspire and move towards the next decade of ASEAN Community building, ASEAN identity building should be less about institutional forms and more about people seeing themselves as belonging to this region. This entails developing friendship to embrace and recognise diversity while realising the similarities that are shared in cultures and heritage of this region. As such, the ASEAN community can move towards truly embodying what it is to 'Think, Feel, and #BeASEAN'.

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